hard to identify the biases, strengths, and weaknesses of foreign election observers' missions. Also, given the NLD won with such a convincing margin, questions of bias were less relevant than if had it won with only a slim majority.

THE TATMADAW

In order to understand the role of the Tatmadaw in Myanmar electoral politics, one must look back to history. As civil war has lasted for many decades, military involvement in politics is strong. As long as the state is weak and unable to manage political instability, military involvement in politics cannot be easily changed, even with good electoral outcomes. On two previous occasions free and fair elections were held under military rule: in 1960, and again in 1990. Yet, these elections were followed by long periods of military rule, and most people have negative views about the military's role in politics since the failed democracy uprising of 1988.

Today it cannot be denied that Myanmar's path to democratization in recent years was made possible by military officers. But even since the transition to democracy began, some civilian posts have been taken by military officers. So in the eyes of Myanmar people, the military continues to be treated with distrust and hostility. Events like the silver jubilee anniversary commemoration of the 1990 election at the Judson Center, and efforts by elected members of parliament from 1990 to launch legal proceedings against some members of the military junta for breaking electoral laws cause uneasiness for the military (Lun Min Maung 2015). Criticism and hatred of the military expressed on Facebook and other social media do little to bring civilians and the military closer together. Yet, without trust between civilians and the military, it will be difficult for the present number of seats in parliament reserved for the military to be reduced from twenty-five per cent.

For its part, the military has been trying to improve its professionalism in order to rid itself of old habits. The National Defence College, which trains colonels and high-ranking officials, has been upgrading its curricula since 2008, after the constitution was promulgated. Courses on civil-military relations, democracy, and human rights are now a part of the curriculum. Visiting military delegations from abroad, such as the United States, embolden the military to open up and re-engage with the West.